> “Initially, when I went up in space, we were totally cut off. So, I had no idea what was happening here. I didn't know it had become a huge deal in India and that people were celebrating this mission, till my wife told me”



AP



HISTORIC HOMECOMING Clockwise from left, school students in Moradabad celebrate the Ax-4 crew's return; Shubhanshu being assisted out of the Crew Dragon spacecraft, Jul. 15; reuniting with his wife Kamna, Jul. 16

Q. Your space trip has also generated a lot of excitement among youngsters.

Yes. That has been an important outcome. The momentum my mission in space has created seems to have inspired youngsters and should draw them into becoming astronauts or space scientists. Because it is not just Gaganyaan, ISRO is also working on India's space station, the Bharatiya Antariksh Station and then, eventually, landing on the Moon by 2040. It has been laid out in the space policy as part of the grand vision of the Honourable Prime Minister. So, I think this mission has generated good momentum.

Q. What is the next frontier for you, apart from Gaganyaan? Are you looking to be India's first man on the Moon?

Absolutely, yes. I tell the kids, who knows, one of you may be the one to set foot on the Moon when we eventually go there in 2040, but I will be fighting you for that part. I would say that whether I or somebody else goes, the important thing is we achieve that aim. We are a country of 1.4 billion people. I understand the implication of me being the one who got to represent the country and I feel extremely fortunate.

Q. You are the 634th astronaut to have gone into space and it has been 64 years since Yuri Gagarin did so. This means an average of only 10 astronauts have gone up annually for the past six decades. But now the world is talking of space tourism and you may have plenty of ordinary individuals going into space without any special training. How does that make you feel?

What is happening is something similar to aviation. First there were the pioneers who slogged it out, developed the aircraft and the machines. Then, there were test pilots who tested those machines. Gradually, they opened the envelope and civil aviation started. Now, you don't even think twice; travel by air is the primary means of travel for a lot of people. Something of that kind of transition may be happening in space as well. Right now, it's a very niche activity. Only a very few train and go up into space. They are the ones doing the science, taking the risks and proving systems for everyone else to follow. Eventually, people would be able to travel frequently to space and come back. A space tourist should get the chance to go and do it. Going to space gives you a different perspective. So, the more people experience it, the better it can help all of us back here. ■